

Having attempted thus to answer the question as to the affinities of the Magi on the eastern side of their native land, we may proceed to ask whether they had affinities on the west. It will be convenient to enlarge the question to include Parsism as we have it, whether Magian or Iranian, reformed or unreformed. How far, then, is Babylonian civilisation responsible for Avestan ideas? There is a strong party among Oriental historians who are bent on finding Babylon everywhere. I am not an expert in Semitic matters, and shall not even ask the obvious questions as to the evidence on which we are to regard the Babylonian mind as the one great original force in Oriental thought. But before I shut myself up within my own proper corner, I cannot help expressing satisfaction in some signs of the times. I am not listening for the shout, "Babylon the Great is fallen," from serried ranks of scholarship; but some check to the extravagance of a few learned enthusiasts is not unwelcome. My predecessor in this Lectureship, Dr Farnell, has in his *Greece and Babylon* rescued Hellas from absorption; and believers in the most original nation of history will read his concluding sentence with relief:—

So far, then, as our knowledge goes at present, there is no reason for believing that nascent Hellenism, wherever else arose the streams that nourished its spiritual life, was fertilised by the deep springs of Babylonian religion or theosophy.

With this we may set the rebuke which professional astronomers have been administering to a distinguished group of Assyriologists who have built up a system of "Astral Mythology" without apparently